German Idealism Reading Group

Columbia University

Faculty Sponsor: Axel Honneth

Meetings: Fridays, 4-6pm in 302 Philosophy Hall

Topic: Kant's Ethics.

Description: We'll work through Kant's three major published works on ethics chronologically: the *Groundwork for the Metaphysics of Morals* (1785), the *Critique of Practical Reason* (1788), and the Doctrine of Virtue in the *Metaphysics of Morals* (1797). Topics included will be moral normativity, duty, happiness, action, autonomy, freedom, the will, conscience, the highest good, rational faith, moral education, virtue, duties to oneself, duties to others, perfect duties, and imperfect duties.

Schedule of Readings

Week **Reading(s)**

1 Introduction to the Kantian Ethical Project

- *GMM*: Preface, Transition from the Ordinary Rational Knowledge of Morality to the Philosophical, & Transition from Popular Moral Philosophy to a Metaphysics of Morality (excerpt 1) (387-406 / 1-24)

Optional further readings:

- Korsgaard, Kant's Analysis of Obligation
- Herman, On the Value of Acting from the Motive of Duty
- Ameriks, Kant on the Good Will

2 The Categorical Imperative

- *GMM*: Transition from Popular Moral Philosophy to a Metaphysics of Morals (excerpt 2) (414-445 / 25-48)

Optional further readings:

- Korsgaard, Creating the Kingdom of Ends
- Engstrom, The Categorical Imperative

3 Morality & Freedom

- *GMM*: Transition from a Metaphysics of Morals to a Critique of Pure Practical Reason (446-463 / 49-62)
- *CPR*: Preface & Introduction (3-16 / 3-13)

Optional further readings:

- Ameriks, Kant's Deduction of Freedom and Morality
- Henrich, Die Deduktion des Sittengesetzes

4 The Will & the Moral Law

- *CPR*: The Analytic of Pure Practical Reason (excerpt 1) (19-57 / 17-48)

Optional further readings:

- Korsgaard, Skepticism about Practical Reason

5 Moral Motivation

- *CPR*: Analytic of Pure Practical Reason (excerpt 2) (57-89 / 49-73)

Optional further readings:

- Reath, Kant's Theory of Moral Sensibility
- McCarty, Kantian Moral Motivation and the Feeling of Respect

6 Freedom in a Deterministic World

- *CPR*: Analytic of Pure Practical Reason (excerpt 3) (89-106 / 73-86)

Optional further readings:

- Wood, Kant's Compatibilism

7 The Postulates of Practical Reason

- *CPR*: Dialectic of Pure Practical Reason (excerpt 1) (107-134 / 87-107)

Optional further readings:

- Pasternack, Restoring Kant's Conception of the Highest Good
- Chignell, Belief in Kant

8 Theoretical Constraints & Moral Cultivation

- *CPR*: Dialectic of Pure Practical Reason (excerpt 2) (134-148 / 108-118)
- *CPR*: Doctrine of the Method of Pure Practical Reason (151-163 / 121-130)

Optional further readings:

- Bacin, The Meaning of the Critique of Practical Reason for Moral Beings

9 Foundations of the Doctrine of Virtue

- *MM*: Introduction to the Metaphysics of Morals (211-221 / 11-25)
- *MM*: Preface to the Doctrine of Virtue (375-378 / 151-153)
- *MM*: Introduction to the Doctrine of Virtue (excerpt 1) (379-385 / 155-160)

Optional further readings:

- Allison, Wille, Willkür, and Gesinnung
- Engstrom, Reason, Desire, and the Will

10 Duty & Virtue

- *MM*: Introduction to the Doctrine of Virtue (excerpt 2) (385-413 / 160-181)

Optional further readings:

- Denis, Kant's Conception of Virtue
- Hill, Kantian Virtue and 'Virtue Ethics'

11 Duties to Oneself

- *MM*: Doctrine of the Elements of Ethics: On Duties to Oneself as Such (417- 447 / 185-212)

Optional further readings:

- Hill, Servility and Self-Respect
- Bacin, The Perfect Duty to Oneself Merely as a Moral Being

12 Duties to Others

- *MM*: Doctrine of the Elements of Ethics: On Duties of Virtue to Others (448-474 / 213-236)

Optional further readings:

- Baron, Love and Respect in the Doctrine of Virtue
- Velleman, Love as a Moral Emotion

13 Moral Cultivation

- *MM*: Doctrine of the Methods of Ethics (447-491 / 239-250)

Optional further readings:

- Timmons, Moral Education and Practice

Abbreviations:

GMM = Groundwork for the Metaphysics of Morals

CPR = Critique of Practical Reason

MM = Metaphysics of Morals